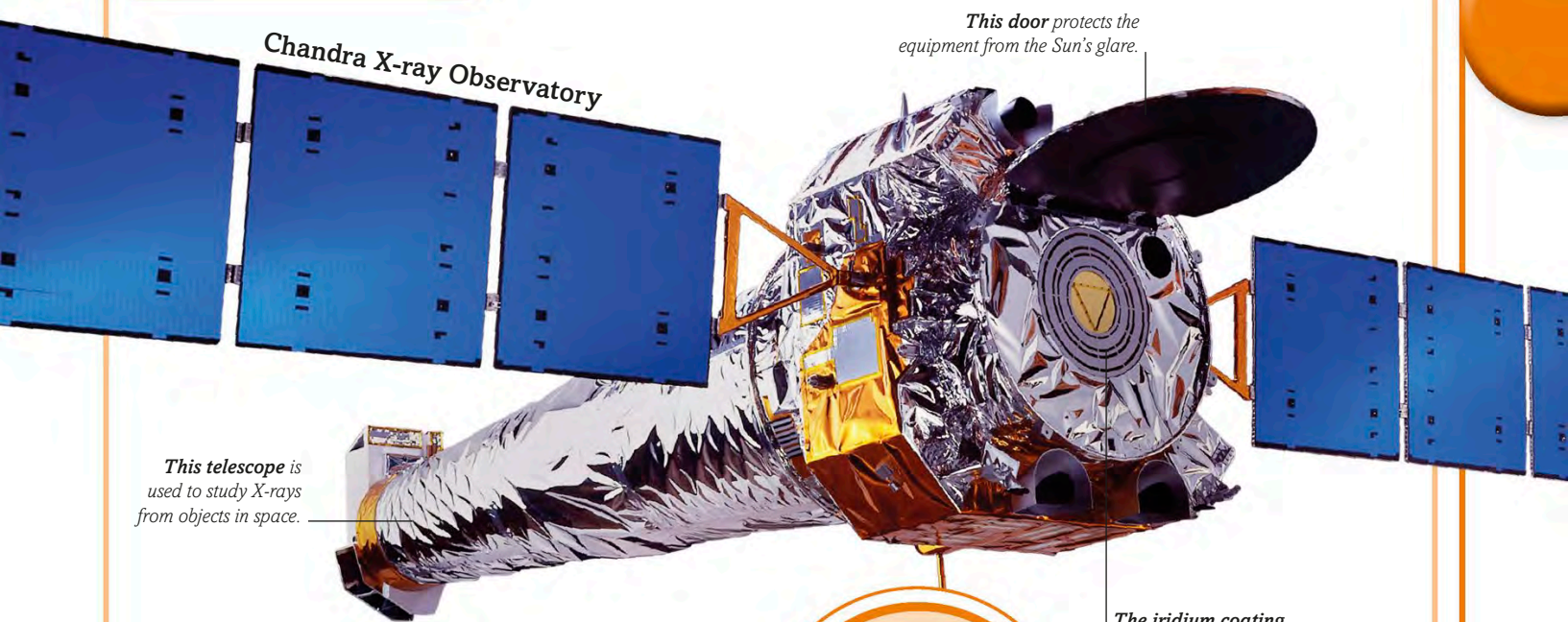


Uses



Chandra X-ray Observatory

This telescope is used to study X-rays from objects in space.

This door protects the equipment from the Sun's glare.

This spark plug contains a tiny amount of iridium, and can resist the high temperatures created during sparking in vehicles.

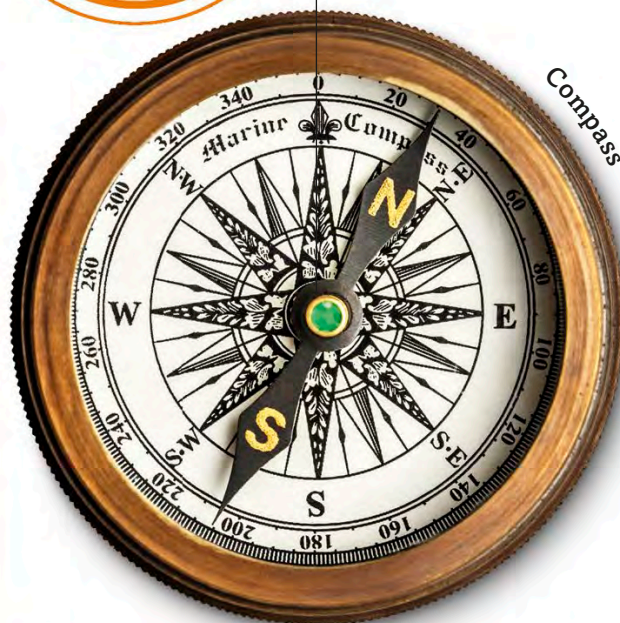


Spark plug

Iridium is the **second densest metal**, after osmium.

The iridium coating on the mirror is only a few atoms thick.

The moving parts of some compasses are made of the alloy osmiridium.



Compass



LUIS WALTER ALVAREZ



In 1980, the American physicist Luis Walter Alvarez and his son Walter discovered a layer of iridium-rich clay in rocks all over the world. They suggested that this was the result of a meteorite impact about 66 million years ago, which led to the extinction of the dinosaurs.

explosion 66 million years ago when a large meteorite hit our planet. The applications of this element include coating the mirror of NASA's **Chandra X-ray Observatory**, an Earth-orbiting telescope that studies X-rays from distant stars. Iridium is more durable

than platinum and copper, and is therefore preferred over these metals for use in spark plugs. Iridium is also mixed with osmium to make an alloy called osmiridium, which is used in **compasses** and put in nibs for some fountain pens to make them hardy.